

The Yes Men

Bhopal, a city of two beautiful lakes and a remarkable cultural legacy, is today remembered as the site of the world's worst industrial disaster. On the night of December 2, 1984, a deadly MIC (methyl isocyanate) gas leak from Union Carbide's factory killed around 8,000 people in the first seventy-two hours alone. This number has gone up to 25,000 in the last twenty-six years.

Today, an entire generation lives with the effects of the gas exposure, and their children are being born with severe physical and mental disabilities. More than 37,000 people are forced to live with contaminated ground water. The disaster continues and so does the struggle by the victims of Dow-Carbide poisons. Till date, no one has been prosecuted – Warren Anderson remains an absconder, and Dow Chemicals refuses to accept any liability for the Bhopal disaster. Even though Dow Chemical has accepted Union Carbide liabilities in Texas, for workers who were affected by Asbestos (produced by Union Carbide), when it comes to Bhopal, they seem to display double standards.

However, the people of Bhopal are not alone in their struggle; the injustice they have suffered and the moral strength of their demands have won them support across the world. In this context the role played by The Yes Men has been truly remarkable. The Yes Men have initiated a series of actions highlighting the Bhopal struggle.

On the 20th anniversary of the disaster, when Dow had newly acquired Union Carbide, to become the largest and richest chemical corporation in the world, The Yes Men appeared on the BBC, posing as Dow executives, and accepting all responsibilities related to the disaster. Nine years later, when Dow was organizing a global 'Blue planet Run', promoting safe water, even as it continued to ignore the plight of more than 25,000 people in Bhopal who were forced to live with the contaminated groundwater, The Yes Men distributed Beau' pal water bottles. Again, a year later when Dow sponsored the Live Earth Run, The Yes Men appeared in New York criticizing the protesters for their

optimism – that one day justice will be done. Each time, Dow had to make a public statement that they would never own-up to the Bhopal liabilities.

With each of their actions The Yes Men have not only embarrassed Dow Chemical, but also exposed the truth and unmasked its 'human element'.

Their kind of activism has inspired actions across the world – both online as well as offline. These actions though publicised, as 'spoofs', in effect expose the many contradictions between the powerless and powerful, and the extent to which their greed for money and power can maim and victimise the world in reality. In a similar vein comes the release of their much-acclaimed film – The Yes Men Fix The World.

This film chronicles their consistent efforts towards strengthening the people's struggle against corporate greed, and accepting accountability. The film raises critical questions, calls on the audience to take action, and sends a warning to the mighty and powerful against any misgivings that they might have with regards to the public, the strength of their struggle and the support they inspire worldwide.

For more information please visit www.bhopal.net and www.studentsforbhopal.org, or email rachnya@gmail.com. 



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The Yes Men: Andy Bichlbaum and Mike Bonanno